could be ignored. A uniform was a guarantee as far as pick-ups were concerned. In all my stay in the Army, I never had any difficulty in getting a ride.

I had only occasionally been in automobiles in my life. I had never been in a car on a modern intercity highway before. Certainly, I had never experienced hour after hour of smooth sixty-miles-an-hour driving before. No words could express my admiration for the driver. It took him three hours to reach the train station in Washington, and I stumbled incoherently in my attempts to thank him. He waved it away nonchalantly and drove off. 4

I was down at Brighton Beach at eleven forty-five and saw Ger-

4 Later on, I became more nonchalant myself. A simple "Thank you" proved to be enough.

trude for the first time in thirty-one days. This time she had reserved the room at the hotel, and oh my goodness, was that different from sleeping in the barracks!

On the evening of December 2, I set out on the return journey. Getting to Washington was no problem, but once there, it was useless to expect to hitch a ride late at night to Petersburg. I had to take a midnight train—and not the kind of train that made the run between the big cities of the Northeast. It was a wretched, slow, uncomfortable horror of a train on which I had to sit up all night, packed in with many other soldiers, and with civilians as well. I got into camp at 5 :oo a.m. on December 3.

8

There was one drawback to the furlough and that was the fact that I had an infected right big toenail, which grew worse and worse till I could barely walk.

I had tried everything from soaking in Epsom salts to the application of some sulfa drug preparation. In the end, half the nail had to be cut away.

It was done in two installments. On December 15, the doctor swabbed it with a liquid and it grew very cold. I assumed he was using ethyl chloride, which evaporates so quickly it freezes the skin temporarily and makes it incapable of feeling pain. "He quick-froze it," I said in my diary. Sure enough, it didn't hurt.